DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Is Less Torah Sometimes More?

Derech Hashem 4:2:7

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 2, paragraph 7 (end of the chapter), with an introduction to Chapter 3 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 27 January 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: the two conditions

This short recording finishes the chapter on Torah study; the class continues in the next recording. The Rabbi reviewed: all service of God divides into action and study. The purpose of study is not only to know what to do; God tied into Torah a light and spiritual energy He placed in nothing else, the highest there is. When you read or think about the words of Tanakh, and most of all when you do both, you can bring that light down, provided you meet two conditions.

The group recalled them: first, reverence, recognising that we are not reading a newspaper; second, working on one's character. "None of us are perfect. We're not going to become perfect. But at least the intent to do so."

And even one who is not there yet should study, because a flicker of light can reignite him. The one exception is studying to mock or to undermine: the Torah, or other people. That is worse than *shelo lishmah*. Learning for honour, money or intellectual interest is *shelo lishmah*: "it's not the ideal, but study with that and hopefully one day you'll become better". But learning to catch out your teacher or your friend, or to find something "not politically correct today in the Torah" and use it to mock, means you will never get even a flicker of light.

Paragraph 7: preparation adds weight

The final paragraph: one who purifies and sanctifies his deeds draws down a level of influence in proportion to his preparation, and the more he prepares, the more he increases the *yekar*, the weight and preciousness, of his study. If you go to the mikveh, or pause in the middle of learning for five minutes to think about what it is all about, you learn for less time, but you increase the value of your learning.

This is why the Torah crowned the great sages of the Gemara with such strength, and why we do not find it in later generations: their preparation was greater. The Rabbi brought the famous Gemara that when Yonatan ben Uziel studied Torah, any bird that flew over him was burned, because of the great divine presence resting upon him.

So do not think that time spent preparing takes away from Torah. "It's not about the quantity. It's about the quality."

The meat and the gravy

The Rabbi gave an example. One yeshivah student learns twelve hours a day. Another learns ten, and spends the other two on preparation: half an hour of musar, half an hour arranging his thoughts, half an hour at the mikveh. The second has more weight to his learning.

But do not go overboard. "This is the sauce around the gravy, around the meat." If the preparations become the meat, ten hours of preparation and two hours of study, then you have it the wrong way round. A participant summed it up: a smaller piece of meat with flavour is better than a huge piece without.

Learning and the world

A participant asked: is the purpose of Torah study to study Torah, or to make a better world? Paragraph 4 said every part of Torah can perfect part of creation. Surely, he said, study should show itself in behaviour that is an example to others; people do not knock on the yeshivah door asking to see how a Jew lives, they see how he behaves outside.

The Rabbi agreed: that is the whole point, improving one's character through study and so bringing perfection to creation. He said that, in his view, a person should be in full-time learning when he is training towards something, such as becoming a rabbi who will give back to the community, or when he is teaching and must constantly study. In earlier generations, he said, there were always some people who learned the whole day, to answer the community's questions, but the idea that everyone should study full-time for years is, in his view, a modern development.

Looking ahead: love and fear of God

Chapter 3 begins the first category of action: the constant misvot. Recall the four kinds: constant, such as love and fear of God; daily, such as Tefillah and Shema; occasional, such as the festivals; and circumstantial, such as a mezuzah. So the next chapter, on page 128, deals with the love and fear of God. At that point the Rabbi started a new recording.

Summary

- The two conditions for Torah study are reverence and working on one's character.
- Learning *shelo lishmah* is acceptable; learning to mock or undermine is not.
- Preparation such as musar, reflection and mikveh adds weight to one's learning.
- Quality matters more than quantity, but preparation must not crowd out the learning itself.
- Torah study should express itself in character and conduct that improve the world.

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